

THE FIELD BATTLE

The King's Crusade – Module Nine

OVERVIEW

The coalition marches on Caer Ysolde, and Vale's occupation makes its first attempt to stop that march in the open rather than from behind a wall — a field army under General Ilyana Voss, meaning to catch the coalition's column strung out and unprepared. It does not work, and this module is the campaign's proof, stated in blood rather than in a speech, that Vale's army can be beaten in a fair fight. That proof costs something. Core scenes run four to four and a half hours; Optional Content fills out the rest of a five-hour session and can be cut if the table is short on time.

A BATTLE, NOT A MASSACRE

Vindana fell partly through the party's own cleverness and partly through Xavier's extraordinary intervention. This battle should not repeat either trick — it is won by discipline, by a column that holds formation under pressure the way Richard's did at the historical Arsuf, and by the party's own competence in a fight that is genuinely dangerous rather than pre-decided. Let the danger be real.

Scene	Target time	Notes
1. The Column Strung Out	20–30 min	The ambush begins to reveal itself.
2. Tam's Warning	20–30 min	The module's cost — or its alternate. Read carefully before running.
3. Holding the Line	60–90 min	The battle itself. DC table and stat block below.
4. The Rout	30–45 min	General Voss's line breaks. Proof, not celebration.
Optional Content	30–45 min	Run if the table has time; cut cleanly if not.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

General Voss is a real tactician and her ambush is a genuinely good plan — she has read the coalition's march discipline correctly and is exploiting the one moment a column is actually vulnerable, the transition from road formation to battle formation. It very nearly works. What defeats her is not a trick or a twist; it is the coalition holding its nerve and its lines exactly long enough for the party, and Tam Ondry's warning, to buy the time Xavier's officers need to form up properly.

DM Only: this module defaults to Tam Ondry dying in Scene 2, delivering the warning that saves the column. He is not fridged for shock value — his death is the direct, earned cost of a warning that genuinely matters, and it should be played with the same weight Module Five gave his

introduction. If your table has grown attached to him and you would rather not lose him, the alternate in Scene 2 below turns his warning into the discovery of a third captive member of the royal house instead, opening a rescue thread rather than closing a life. Choose deliberately, not by default.

SCENE 1: THE COLUMN STRUNG OUT

The coalition's march north from Vindana is disciplined but long, strung across miles of road through country that stopped being safely held the moment it stopped being inside sight of the city's walls. The first sign of trouble is not an attack — it is an absence.

The scouts who should have reported in an hour ago have not, and the ones sent after them have not come back either. Somewhere ahead, past a treeline that should not be able to hide as much as it apparently does, the road goes quiet in a way that has nothing to do with Elduvaine's habits and everything to do with an army waiting for the right moment.

Let the party notice the wrongness before the coalition's officers do — an Investigation or Survival check (DC 13) reads the terrain as a natural ambush site, or Insight (DC 13) reads the missing scouts as deliberate rather than delayed. This scene's job is dread, not combat; end it on the certainty that something is about to happen, not on contact.

SCENE 2: TAM'S WARNING

A rider comes back down the column at a dead run — the same shape of scene as Module Five's Scene 1, deliberately, because it is the same man doing the same job one more time.

Tam Ondry doesn't bother reining in properly, half-falling out of the saddle in his hurry to reach an officer, anyone, with rank enough to matter. "Ambush — treeline, both sides, more of them than us if they catch us stretched out like this — you have to form up now, not in a minute, now —" An arrow that was aimed at someone else entirely finds him mid-sentence.

RUNNING THE DEFAULT SCENE

Tam's warning reaches the column's officers in time regardless of what the party does — that is not in question, and the party cannot fail to receive it. What is in question is whether they reach him before the end. A DC 16 Medicine check, attempted within the first round after he falls, stabilises him long enough for a few last words; failing that check, or simply not reaching him in time, means he dies having delivered exactly the warning he came to give, aware that it worked. Either way, this is the module's emotional cost, and it should be allowed to land before Scene 3's battle begins.

THE ALTERNATE: A THIRD THREAD

If your table would rather not lose Tam, run this instead: his warning is the same and he survives it, but what he saw scouting ahead of the ambush was not only Voss's army. It

was a small column under Elduvish colours moving the other way, unhurried, barely escorted, with a grey-haired elf riding in the middle of it who was not tied to anything and did not look like a prisoner. That is Emrys Ysolde, the Envoy, being moved somewhere quieter – and the reason Tam mentions the detail at all is that nobody in the column was guarding him so much as accompanying him.

DM Only: if the party pulled Serjeant Hoth’s file out of Sennoch Hall in Module Four, they already have the first hard evidence that Emrys has spent three years talking to Vale. This is where that stops being a document and becomes a man on a road. He is not a traitor, there is no reveal, and he will not defend himself: he took the only job nobody else in his house would take, and he cannot produce a clean accounting of whether it helped. What his sister’s physician, the published levy and two mass reprisals that did not happen actually cost is a question he has had three years to word and still cannot answer. Open the thread here and let it stay open.

Do not run both versions of this scene. Pick one before the session and commit to it.

SCENE 3: HOLDING THE LINE

The ambush breaks from both treelines at once, and for several very long minutes the outcome is genuinely uncertain. This is the module’s real fight, and it should feel like one.

The coalition line buckles and does not break – Oksitan spears on the left with a dragonborn house-knight somewhere in the middle of them roaring instructions nobody can hear, Auberitz heavier foot anchoring the centre, Harrowmark’s own discipline holding a flank that has no business holding against these numbers. Somewhere in the press, unmistakable even through a helm, is a woman directing Voss’s attack with the calm of someone who still, even now, believes this is winnable.

RUNNING THE SCENE

Use Legionaries of the Sixth (Bestiary, CR 1/2) for General Voss’s rank and file – six of them, engaging the party and the coalition line in waves rather than all at once, with Formation working every time two of them reach the same target – and General Voss herself (see Stat Block) as the encounter’s real threat, seeking out whoever on the coalition side looks most like a commander to kill or capture. If the party has protected Xavier’s officers or otherwise distinguished themselves, Voss may target them directly, which is a genuine compliment from an enemy tactician and should read as one.

SCALING THE FIGHT

Voss (1,800 XP) plus six Legionaries of the Sixth (100 XP each, 600) totals 2,400 base XP across seven monsters, which sits in the 7–10 band: ×2.5 at party sizes three to five, for 6,000 adjusted, and ×2 at six or more, for 4,800. The table below is computed at 7th level, because that is where most tables will actually be by Module Nine – but this campaign prescribes no milestone schedule, so check it against your own party’s real level before you run it.

PCs	Adj. XP	Hard	Deadly	Reads as
4 at 7th	6,000	4,400	6,800	Hard, close to Deadly. Run as written.

PCs	Adj. XP	Hard	Deadly	Reads as
5 at 7th	6,000	5,500	8,500	Hard. This is the calibration the module wants.
6 at 7th	4,800	6,600	10,200	Medium. Add two more legionaries, not a second officer.
4 at 5th	6,000	3,000	4,400	Well past Deadly. Cut to four legionaries.

This is deliberately the most dangerous fight in the campaign so far, and unlike every earlier encounter it is meant to read Hard rather than Easy-to-Medium. If it comes out too heavy against your own table, remove legionaries rather than reducing Voss – she is the fight’s whole point, and a Voss who is not frightening has cost the module its subject.

STAT BLOCK

General Ilyana Voss

Medium humanoid (orc), lawful neutral – SRD Gladiator, renamed

Armor Class: 16 (studded leather armor, shield)

Hit Points: 112 (15d8 + 45)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	15 (+2)	16 (+3)	10 (+0)	12 (+1)	15 (+2)

Saving Throws: Str +7, Dex +5, Con +6

Skills: Athletics +10, Intimidation +5

Senses: passive Perception 11

Languages: Common

Challenge: 5 (1,800 XP)

Brave. Voss has advantage on saving throws against being frightened.

Brute. A melee weapon deals one extra die of its damage when Voss hits with it (included in the attacks below).

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Voss makes three melee attacks or two ranged attacks.

Spear. Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. Hit: 11 (2d6 + 4) piercing damage, or 13 (2d8 + 4) piercing damage if used with two hands to make a melee attack.

Shield Bash. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. Hit: 9 (2d4 + 4) bludgeoning damage. If the target is Medium or smaller, it must succeed on a DC 15 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone.

REACTIONS

Parry. Voss adds 3 to her AC against one melee attack that would hit her. To do so, she must see the attacker and be wielding a melee weapon.

TIERED SKILL DCs

Easy 10, Moderate 13, Hard 16, matching the tiers used throughout this campaign.

Task	Skill	DC	Tier
Read the treeline as a prepared ambush site	Investigation / Survival	13	Moderate
Recognise the missing scouts as deliberate	Insight	13	Moderate
Stabilise Tam Ondry after he falls (default Scene 2)	Medicine	16	Hard
Hold a coalition position against Voss's pressure	Athletics / relevant combat skill	13	Moderate
Talk Voss into a battlefield surrender once clearly beaten	Persuasion / Intimidation	16	Hard

SCENE 4: THE ROUT

Once General Voss falls, is captured, or breaks off — a defeated field commander she genuinely is not the type to flee cleanly, but she will disengage if the fight is unambiguously lost rather than die for nothing — her line comes apart within minutes. This is proof, not celebration.

It is not a rout in the way stories tell it — no cheering, no clean lines of fleeing soldiers. It is simply, suddenly, over: Voss's remaining troops breaking for the treeline they came from, the coalition too battered and too relieved to give proper chase, and a field that will need a great deal of tending before anyone can say anything about who won it that does not sound obscene.

Let the aftermath be heavy rather than triumphant, especially if Tam died in Scene 2 — the coalition has proven something real about Vale's army today, and it cost real people to prove it. End the session on that weight rather than on a victory speech. Hand off directly to Module Ten for the approach to Caer Ysolde.

PUZZLES AND SET PIECES

The five movements are the module's existing scenes, sequenced, with the party put at the hinge of each. Voss's Field Orders is additive: fifteen minutes, and it changes the casualty list rather than the outcome.

THE PUZZLE: VOSS'S FIELD ORDERS

General Ilyana Voss writes her orders in the Legion's working cipher, which is not a cipher so much as a professional shorthand a hundred and forty years old. Any captured dispatch is readable and the reading is a genuine puzzle rather than a check.

The Sixth writes movement as three elements: the company number, the hour on a twelve-mark day, and a bearing given as a clock face from the standard. Nothing is written in words, because words can be read by anybody and numbers can be read by a professional.

What is written	What it means	How a party can establish it
IV · iii · x	Fourth company, third hour, bearing ten o'clock	Compare any two dispatches against movements the party watched happen.
A doubled numeral	The order is a feint and is to be seen	The only dispatches ever sent uncovered are doubled. Two examples is enough.
A struck-through hour	Hold until countermanded	A prisoner will confirm this without considering it a betrayal, because it is drill, not intelligence.
No bearing at all	Reserve. Committed at the commander's word only	This is the one that matters and it is the one the party will find last.

Put together, three captured dispatches tell the party where Voss's reserve is and that she has not yet committed it — which is the single most valuable piece of information available on the field, and which the coalition's own scouts have failed to get for two days.

DM Only: give them a real advantage for solving it. A party that finds the reserve and tells Xavier changes the shape of the battle, and the DM should say so in narration: the coalition's left does not break, and about four hundred people who would have died do not. Do not make this the difference between victory and defeat — the field battle is won either way, because the campaign needs it won — make it the difference in the casualty list, and read part of the casualty list out.

SET PIECE: THE BATTLE, IN FIVE MOVEMENTS

Eight thousand people on each side and five characters somewhere in the middle of it. The party cannot win a field battle and should never be asked to; what they can do is be the hinge at five specific moments, and the module is built to put them at each one.

- The Approach.** Two hours of standing in a line while the enemy does the same thing four hundred yards away. Nothing happens. This is deliberate and should be played straight — the fear in a set battle is almost all in the waiting, and a DM who skips it has thrown away the only chance to make the rest of it land.
- The Left Gives.** Oksitan spears, already shaken by what happened to their king, bend and do not break. The party is behind them and can see it happening before anyone in command can. A dragonborn house-knight is somewhere in the middle of that line roaring instructions nobody can hear.
- The Ironshanks.** The Sixth's heavy foot come through the gap in a shield wall and the party is what is in front of

them. Four ironshanks and an optio, in the open, with the battle noise making every command a shouted argument. This is the module's real fight and it should be genuinely frightening.

4. **The Reserve.** Voss commits, or does not, depending on the puzzle above. If the party found it, the coalition meets it ready. If not, it arrives on the flank and the module gets a sixth movement nobody wanted.
5. **Voss.** She does not flee and she does not die swinging. When the field is lost she stops, puts her sword point down in the mud, and waits, because she is a professional on a contract and the contract does not require this. What the party does about that is the end of the session.

DM Only: a captured Voss is worth more to this campaign than a dead one by a wide margin and the module should not tip the scale. She will not be turned, will not inform, and will not apologise for any of it — and she will, if asked correctly, explain exactly what the Sixth's contract says and when it expires, which is information nobody else in Elduvaine will give the party and which matters enormously in Module Eleven.

NPC PROFILES

GENERAL ILYANA VOSS

An orc, and a career soldier of the sort every army wants and few can keep. She came up through the same legion Drell did and outgrew it; she commands Vale's field army because she is the best available person to command it, and she has never in her life been asked to believe in anything. The campaign makes no comment anywhere about the fact that orcs hunt wyverns for Harrowmark at Greywatch and command armies for Vale in the field. Neither should any NPC. Let the players sit with it.

A real tactician rather than a fanatic, calm under pressure in a way that reads as competence rather than menace. Speech, in the brief window a table might hear her actually speak (command orders during the fight, or a surrender if the party earns one): direct, economical, entirely without contempt for an enemy who is currently winning.

Open thread: if captured rather than killed, Voss is a genuine long-term asset for the coalition — a professional soldier with real knowledge of Vale's remaining field strength, who a DM can develop as a reluctant, pragmatic informant in later modules rather than a villain who must be disposed of.

OPTIONAL CONTENT

WHAT THE COLUMN SAYS ABOUT TAM

If Tam died in Scene 2, let the coalition's reaction be genuine rather than perfunctory — a name added to a growing list, spoken plainly rather than eulogised, echoing exactly the register the Standing Water gave the second king's death in Module Five. No mechanical stakes; this is the module giving its cost real weight.

VOSS'S OWN PAPERS

If Voss is captured or her body searched, her own field orders reveal real, specific intelligence about the remaining distance to Caer Ysolde and what defends it — useful DM ammunition for Module Ten rather than something that needs to resolve here.

AN ENGINE BEHIND THE LINE

Voss did not march without one. Behind her reserve, on a cart drawn by eight oxen and guarded by four Legionaries of the Sixth, is a Draining Engine (Bestiary): plated, humming, and drawing the resident magic out of the ground in a slow circle into racks of cut light-stone. The grass for sixty yards round it is the grey of the Dead Mile. Every Elduvish creature within sixty feet of it feels it working, and so does any Elduvish member of the party.

An Engine is an objective, not an opponent. Run it as one: the legionaries hold, the Engine discharges at whoever is closest, and a clock runs — every round it keeps working is a round of the Living Realm going into a cart. Breaking it is a real and permanent win. Tell the party what a prisoner or Ninian will tell them if asked: there are only about thirty of these in Elduvaine. Let them do that arithmetic themselves.

DM Only: this is the campaign's cleanest answer to a table that wants to hurt Vale before Module Eleven. The Engine (2,300 XP) and its four legionaries (400) are 2,700 XP across five monsters, $\times 2$ for 5,400 adjusted, or $\times 1.5$ for 4,050 with six characters. At 7th level that is Hard for four characters, Medium to Hard for five and Easy-Medium for six. Track how many Engines the party breaks across the campaign; it belongs in the Branch Ledger.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

- **Which Scene 2 was run.** Tam's death or the third-thread alternate — record which, since it changes what Module Ten and beyond can reference.
- **General Voss's fate.** Killed, captured, or fled — a captured Voss is a real long-term asset; track it the same way Marshal Drell's fate was tracked in Module Seven.

LOOT

- **Voss's field orders.** Real intelligence about Caer Ysolde's defences — see Optional Content.
- **A cloak of elvenkind.** Off one of Voss's scouts, and Elduvish work — which is to say looted, three years ago, from somebody who is not alive to want it back. A DM who wants that to land can let the party find out whose it was.

- **Captured field equipment.** Modest but genuine — weapons, armour, and supply recovered from Voss's broken column, worth collecting rather than a windfall.

THE REFRAIN

*By thought, and by word, and by deed,
the king's own chosen kept their creed.
Far from home, where the quiet land lay,
they held the line, and would not stray.*